

PURNIMA DEVI BARMAN, 46
Conservation biologist and community mobiliser
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tity. From barely 115 birds in the 1990s, the Greater Adjutant population in Assam has grown to more than 1,800 now.

Saving the Hargila (literally 'bone swallower' in Assamese) has brought Barman some prestigious global conservation honours, such as the Whitley Gold Award (2022), a feature in *Time* magazine's Women of the Year (2025) and, this year, the National Geographic Wayfinder Award. Barman, though, feels her greatest prize has been changing the fate of the man-sized bird while also bringing a transformation in people's outlooks. ■

—***Riddhi Rishika***